

blessed with individual brilliance but we didn't take help from the experts as to how we could stay on top."

It may sound like an old player's tale about the horrors of astroturf and a lack of physical fitness, but it is not. A former player said the cumulative burden of India's problems—poor domestic structures, old-fashioned coaching, no support—has had the most damaging impact.

An Indian forward who moves to the international level has grown up being marked by defenders a good distance from him. While playing for India, the defender's teeth are near the forward's collar. Creating space with very little time on the ball is what Indians learn to do not in their formative years but during international matches. Goalkeeper Adrian D'Souza needs a range of drag flickers, not one or two, hammering at him to build his experience of the technique and give him a better chance of reading penalties.

Our coaching needs streamlining with coaches at junior and senior, state and national level teaching the sports science off a common, modern template. Menezes remembers his first international match against Holland and its feared drag flicker Bram Lomans. Rather than receiving guidance about facing Lomans, Menezes' coach told him to expect the Dutchman to "flick the ball". Menezes laughs, "A spectator could have told me that. What I wanted to know where the stick would be coming from, what was the angle, which flank, but as players we had to learn at the top. It was swim or sink."

So Let's Sack All Coaches?

Doesn't work, even though Indian hockey sets the global pace on sackings. The last five-year count is this: current coach Spaniard Jose Brasa was preceded by Carvalho who was preceded by V. Bhaskaran (in his

fourth stint) who was preceded by Gerhard Rach who was assistant to Rajinder Singh who was sacked 24 days before the 2004 Olympics. In this time Charlesworth came and went as technical director and Harinder Singh floated as assistant and coach-in-charge.

An Indian coach's life is like a gossipy MMS, short and dirty. The turgid bureaucracy of the Sports Authority of India (SAI) is the source of their grime. In 2007, Carvalho asked for new hockey sticks before leaving for a tournament in Germany. A SAI official told him curtly that he could only get 22 of the 36 sticks needed. The next item on his agenda being shoes, the India coach then went into the SAI storeroom to see what kind were available. Stacked there, he says, were "about 400 new hockey sticks, the kind I'd asked for, just lying around". The SAI official offered him the telephone numbers of a series of higher-ups who then wouldn't answer the phone. It's not all. The science of physical conditioning is turned into a nutrient checklist from an ancient SAI laboratory. Trying to help the coach out, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh once asked a SAI director-general (DG) why the team couldn't train under floodlights (to simulate international conditions) at SAI's centre in Bangalore. The DG said it would cost Rs 2.5 crore. Crippling!

Do the Best Have Big Bucks?

No. Olympic champions Germany, who will defend their World Cup title in Delhi, run their game on provincial leagues with 370 privately-organised clubs and more than 70,000 registered members. The national team is drawn from the highest 12-team Bundesliga league, the sport is 80 per cent funded by public money with the national team supported by the Deutscher Hockey-Bund (DHB), its national federation and the Ministry of Internal Affairs. There are no professional or semi-professional hockey players in Germany. Nor in Australia, currently ranked number 2 in the world, bronze medallists from 2008 Olympics. Hockey Australia has re-



INDIA, LED BY RAJPAL SINGH (RIGHT), COUNT ON THE EXPERIENCE OF PRABHJOT SINGH (CENTRE) AND ARJUN HALAPPA.

The FIH World Rankings

The teams at World Cup 2010

- 1 Germany
- 2 Australia
- 3 Spain
- 4 Netherlands
- 5 Korea
- 6 England
- 7 Pakistan
- 8 New Zealand
- 11 Canada
- 12 India
- 13 South Africa
- 14 Argentina

World No. 9 Belgium and No. 10 China did not qualify for the 2010 World Cup; India have qualified as the hosts.